Azurelib Academy

Snowflake: Real world interview questions

Question: Can you please let me know about your current roles and responsibilities?

Answer: Currently, I'm working with SunTrust as a senior data engineer, and I have a total of four plus years of experience in the IT industry. My role involves handling all data engineering work using Technologies like Snowflake, AWS, and other traditional ETL tools. I gather requirements from product owners and engineers, develop pipelines, and work on projects from end to end.

Question: What are the source systems in your project, and how have you integrated them with Snowflake?

Answer: In our project, we have multiple source systems, including on-premise databases like Oracle and Netizer, as well as third-party teams that supply campaign information. We use various methods like SFTP, FTP, and Azure Blob Storage to collect data from these sources. We integrate them into Snowflake by utilizing Snowflake features and creating ETL processes.

Question: Why did you choose Snowflake over other cloud platforms like AWS Redshift?

Answer: Snowflake offers several advantages, including the ability to integrate different types of data, whether it's a data lake, data warehouse, or data staging. It simplifies infrastructure management, supports semi-structured data like JSON, and allows for independent scaling of compute and storage, which Redshift doesn't offer.

Question: What types of virtual warehouses have you used in your project?

Answer: We have used single-cluster and multi-cluster virtual warehouses in our project. We create dedicated virtual warehouses

for different teams and adjust their sizes to avoid exceeding costs. For production environments, we use multi-cluster warehouses with standard or economy policies for high availability.

Question: Have you built any pipelines using Snowpipe?

Answer: Yes, we have implemented Snowpipe pipelines in our project. Snowpipe is a continuous data ingestion service in Snowflake that loads files from external stages into Snowflake tables in near real-time, which helps us provide data to teams like Power BI and MicroStrategy quickly.

Question: How do you connect DBT (Data Build Tool) to Snowflake?

Answer: We connect DBT to Snowflake by providing connection details, including the Snowflake account information, unique URL, warehouses, and user credentials. DBT allows us to query tables, views, databases, and schemas in Snowflake using SQL.

Question: If the company wants to move from AWS to another cloud platform in the future, how easy is it to migrate the Snowflake account?

Answer: Migrating the Snowflake account from one cloud platform to another is relatively easy and can be done within a day. Snowflake is cloud-agnostic and allows for data transfer between cloud regions and platforms with minimal effort.

Question: How does Snowflake handle sensitive customer and policy information?

Answer: Snowflake ensures data security by encrypting data at rest and during transfer. It also follows role-based access control (RBAC) policies to restrict access based on user roles. Additionally, Snowflake offers dynamic data masking to protect sensitive data by applying masking policies to specific columns.

Question: Can you explain how Snowflake helps ensure data privacy and security?

Answer: Snowflake provides encryption at rest and during data transfer, and it enforces RBAC policies to control access. It also offers dynamic data masking for sensitive information. Overall, Snowflake prioritizes data privacy and security.

Question: How do you handle sensitive information in the insurance sector, such as customer data and policy information?

Answer: Handling sensitive information in the insurance sector is crucial. Snowflake's security features, including encryption and role-based access control, help us protect customer data and policy information. We also use dynamic data masking to restrict access to specific data elements.

Question : How can user-defined functions be shown in Snowflake?

Answer : User-defined functions in Snowflake can be shown by using the "show functions" command.

Question : How do you call a function in Snowflake?

Answer : To call a function in Snowflake, you can use the "select" function.

Question : What is the syntax for creating a Snowflake task?

Answer : To create a Snowflake task, you use the "create task" statement followed by the task name and specify the warehouse.

Question : How can you load only valid data in Snowflake?

Answer : To load only valid data in Snowflake, you can use a "when" statement to filter the data during the loading process.

Question : How can you check the storage of a table in Snowflake?

Answer : You can check the storage of a table in Snowflake by using storage metrics.

Question : What is the default retention time for tables in Snowflake?

Answer : The default retention time for tables in Snowflake is one day.

Question : What does Snowflake enforce regarding primary keys?

Answer : Snowflake enforces uniqueness for primary keys, but it does not enforce a specific ordering (unary key).

Question : How can you check if a stream has data in Snowflake?

Answer : To check if a stream has data in Snowflake, you can use the "system dollar stream has data" command.

Question : What tools are used for ticketing in Snowflake?

Answer : Ticketing tools in Snowflake are typically obtained from services, and they help manage and track requests and issues.

Question : What are the available databases or instances in Snowflake?

Answer : In Snowflake, you have databases like development, testing, user-accepted testing, and production, which are used for various purposes.

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